17, reports of morgues running out of space and bodies being stored in refrigerated shipping containers began emerging. Such is the virulence of the current wave in the city that 97 per cent of Hong Kong's one million cases have been recorded just in March, and 96 per cent of its 5,401 Covid deaths have been recorded since February 9.

Experts feel this is due to growing pandemic fatigue, when public commitment towards lockdowns and Covid rules starts to waver. "You can keep people locked down only for so long. After that, you need a combination of public awareness of Covid protocols, mass testing, vaccination and treatment facilities to keep the impact of waves low," says Dr Rahul Pandit, director, critical care, at Fortis Mulund, Mumbai, and a member of Maharashtra's Covid-19 task force. In India, people have been widely exposed to the virus, with the last national sero-survey, done in July 2021, indicating that two-thirds have antibodies against Covid-19. This naturally-acquired immunity along with vaccination helped keep the third wave's impact low. However, as this immunity starts to wane with time and Covid mutates to become more contagious, a fourth wave cannot be entirely prevented, say experts. "The virus is finding ways to overcome previous immunity acquired through vaccines or infection. This is particularly dangerous for vulnerable people, like the elderly or comorbid," says Dr Farah Ingale, an internal medicine specialist from Mumbai. This is currently the case with many countries in Europe experiencing a second Omicron wave led by the more infectious sub-variant—BA.2.

BA.2: THE STEALTH VARIANT

India's third wave earlier this year was led by the first Omicron variant, BA.1. Now, it is quickly being replaced the world over by BA.2. The BA.2 sub-variant currently accounts for over 90 per cent of all sequences reported to GISAID, the largest directory of genomic data. The sharp ascent of BA.2 can be seen in the case of Denmark, where its prevalence went from 20 per cent in the last week of December to 66 per cent in the third week of January. A study published in January 2022 on the preprint server medRxiv looked at the two variants



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>
> **Dr RAHUL PANDIT**
> Director, Critical Care,
> Fortis Mulund, Mumbai,

in Denmark between December 2021 and January 2022 and found BA.2 to be 10 per cent more transmissible.

However, the WHO maintains that the difference in transmissibility between both the Omicron sub-variants is minor and not as significant as the difference between BA.1 and Delta (which a French study in January 2022 found to be 105 per cent more contagious). The WHO has also stated that reinfection with BA.2 after infection with BA.1 is rare, although it has been documented. "BA.1 should provide strong protection against reinfection. But we don't know whether or for how long this will hold for other variants," says Dr Ankita Baidya, a Delhi-based infectious disease expert.

Although BA.2 shares many of BA.1's mutations, the two subvariants differ by 28 mutations. In addition, BA.2 carries eight new mutations in the spike protein, according to a study published on medRvix on March 13, 2022. These mutations in BA.2's spikes make it difficult for rapid PCR tests to recognise, earning it the title of 'stealth variant'.

Like BA.1, BA.2 doesn't infect the lungs in the same manner as Delta, but its potential to claim lives cannot be ruled out, particularly among the elderly and the unvaccinated. The US, during its Omicron wave in 2022, reported a peak of 3,500 deaths, the highest since vaccinations began a year ago. "Vaccines help prevent symptomatic infections, hospitalisations and deaths," says Dr Sushila Kataria, senior director of internal medicine at Medanta Hospital, who treated the very first Covid patient in Gurugram back in early 2020. She adds that she has seen the severity of symptoms reduce significantly among her patients and the last difficult case she handled was back in July 2021. "This doesn't mean that Covid cannot still claim lives," she says. "Omicron mostly impacts the upper respiratory tract. The most common symptom is fatigue and often those infected miss diagnosing themselves because the symptoms are so mild. Or people are testing at home using antigen kits but not isolating themselves if the disease is mild. This puts the elderly and comorbid patients at higher risk because Omicron is harder to catch and contain," says Dr Ingale.